The invasion of England offers a prime example of how the Normans waged war. Assembling a fleet of more than 700 vessels to carry around 10,000 men, 3,000 horses, and all the necessary equipment across the Channel showed exceptional organizational ability. At Hastings the Norman tactics were initially to soften up the Anglo-Saxons with a rain of arrows and then launch a cavalry charge against the shield-wall with lances, riding straight-legged in long stirrups on their short, sturdy horses. Later in the battle they feigned a retreat to draw the Anglo-Saxons out of formation, after which the knights could get among them with swords. The Normans' subjection of England after their victory at Hastings showed a ruthless will to power.



Sicilian stronghold
Some of the most enduring monuments to the military power of the Normans are to be found in Sicily, such as this castle perched high on a clifftop at Erice in the west of the island.

"SHIELDS, HELMETS, AND COATS OF MAIL WERE SHIVERED BY THE FURIOUS AND IMPATIENT THRUSTS OF HIS SWORD; SOME HE DASHED TO THE EARTH WITH HIS SHIELD..."

ORDERIC VITALIS DESCRIBING WILLIAM FIGHTING AT THE BATTLE OF HASTINGS



The battle of Hastings
Chainmailed Norman foot soldiers advance to attack the Anglo-Saxon line in a spectacular modern re-enactment of the battle.